Despite the disillusionment with India, because of its role in the US script for Asia, the war in Vietnam heightened the importance of ensuring that India did not fail. As Gaddis has noted, “fear of retreat” had become a great concern for Johnson as he considered his options in Vietnam.[19] Anxious about American credibility abroad and his political credibility at home, a broader fear of retreat meant that Johnson could not just give up on India, no matter how annoyed he was about it getting distracted from its development and defense efforts against China. And, as Fredrik Logevall has noted, Johnson recalled the impact of the loss of China on the Truman administration’s effectiveness.[20] The president did not want to find out the consequences if India, the largest domino still standing, fell.

To prevent such a fall, US efforts in India focused heavily on development for two reasons. First, American intelligence estimates indicated that, while China might nibble at India’s borders, Beijing’s preoccupation with the war in Vietnam meant it was unlikely to undertake any large-scale military action against India.[21] Second, it became evident that India was more vulnerable in the economic realm than in the military one.

As the fall and winter of 1965 progressed, food shortages and the prospect of famine threatened India’s political and economic stability. To some of Johnson’s advisers, the situation called for a loosening of the short-tether policy that had been resumed in late September.[22] The president, however, saw an opportunity to link aid to agricultural and economic reforms, and to pressure India to do more to help itself (via self-sufficiency) and, by extension, to help the free world.[23]

Once again, Delhi would not have disagreed with the goal of strengthening India, but Washington’s preferred means would prove problematic. At the time, Rusk acknowledged the “intrinsic importance of India to us,” but added that it needed to demonstrate actions “to turn swords into plowshares” and “to translate economic promises to [the] Indian people and to [the] US into economic performance.”[24] The first element called for India to make peace with Pakistan, so that China could not continue to take advantage of South Asian discord and India could focus on strengthening itself. It did not, however, constitute US pressure on Kashmir per se. “Kashmir-fixers,” as Bundy and Komer called them, might have been “a plentiful and dangerous commodity” in Washington, but the White House